

China

Exports powered by AI and green tech

April exports beat market expectations by a wide margin against the backdrop of a global manufacturing upturn. Strong momentum was led by AI-related and green-tech products, reinforcing exports as the main growth engine amid weak domestic demand. Rising commodity prices lifted imports value.

- **April: 14.1% y/y for exports, and 25.3% y/y for imports (both in USD terms)**
- **Bloomberg consensus (Barclays): 8.4% y/y (6.5%) for exports, and 20% y/y (18%) for imports**
- **March: 2.5% y/y for exports, and 27.8% y/y for imports (both in USD terms)**

China's export growth returned to double-digit growth, rising to 14.1% y/y in April, far exceeding expectations (Bloomberg 8.4%, Barclays: 6.5%). Such strong exports came against the backdrop of 1) robust uptick in global manufacturing (versus slowing services sector), with global manufacturing PMI rising to a 4-year high in April despite the prolonged energy shock, and 2) strong exports across major manufacturing economies, ranging from low-to-mid product exports from Vietnam (April: 21% y/y), to high-end oriented product exports from Korea (April: 48%), to the full-supply-chain exports from China (April: 14%).

The export momentum is underpinned by high-tech products, particularly AI-related and green-tech goods. The strong global AI capex cycle underpins demand for China's AI-related exports, given the country is a key supplier of AI manufactured components. The breakdown data show that exports of semiconductors (~8% of China's total exports YTD) rose 100% y/y, while exports of automatic data processing equipment and related parts (~6% of China's total exports YTD) increased 47% y/y. We estimate that these two categories together contributed ~8pp to headline exports growth, explaining ~60% of exports growth. For context, China accounts for over 30% of global export value in critical AI-related products, well above Korea (~6%), - including electronic chips, computers, semiconductor components, electrical boards and chip-making equipment.

Turning to green-tech, the ongoing energy supply shock is fuelling Chinese growth by boosting demand for its renewable energy-tech exports. YTD exports data showed strong, double-digit growth in these segments, including EVs (+68% y/y), lithium batteries (+55% y/y), wind turbines (+55% y/y) and solar cells (+34%). We think a prolonged period of geopolitical tensions could accelerate the global green transition, which would ultimately benefit China as the world's leading green-technology powerhouse given the low costs and high quality green products and technologies. Indeed, following the Middle East conflict, we see a surge in export orders for solar

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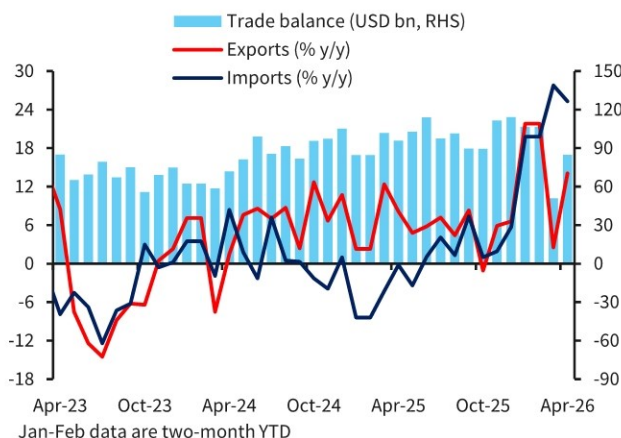
panels, wind turbines, electric vehicles, and other electrified products in the past two months, underscoring how an energy shock can reinforce the shift toward renewables¹.

Looking ahead, we expect exports to remain a critical growth driver this year supported by green-tech, and AI related products. High frequency shipping data showed still strong exports in May. We expect net exports to continue to contribute about 30% of GDP growth this year (2025: 32%), adding 1.4pp to our full-year 2026 GDP growth forecast of 4.6%. By contrast, the contribution from consumption is likely to fall below 50% amid a deteriorating labour market and reduced pro-consumption subsidies. The high-frequency consumption indicators (eg, auto sales, May holiday trip data) weakened visibly in the past month, suggesting consumption will remain a drag on growth in Q2. Overall, we expect the two-speed economy – strong exports versus weak domestic demand – to persist this year.

Details of April export data

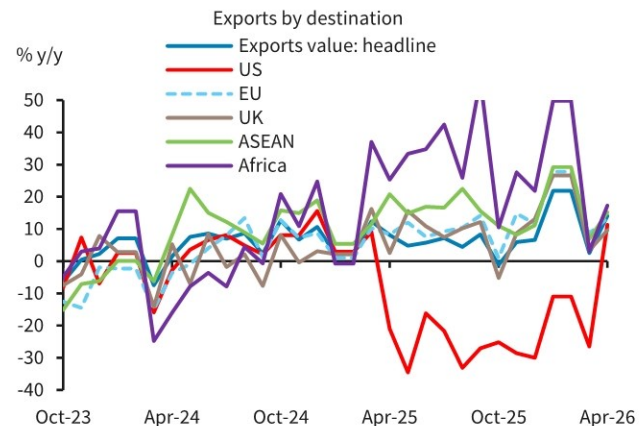
- By destination:** Export growth improved broadly across major markets in April. Shipments to the US rebounded by 11.3% y/y, partly reflecting a low base a year earlier following the Liberation Day tariffs. On a m/m basis, exports to the US surged 24.8%, well above the 2022–24 average of 3.2% (excluding the tariff-affected year of 2025). Export growth to the EU (April: 13.4%, March: 8.6%) and the UK (9.6%, 3.4%) also strengthened. Regional exports to ASEAN (15.2%, 6.9%) and to Japan, Korea and Taiwan (16.8%, 16.0%) posted double-digit gains. Meanwhile, shipments to Africa and LatAm accelerated meaningfully, contributing 2.1pp to headline export growth in April, compared with a drag of 0.1pp in March.
- By product:** Most major export categories accelerated in April. Semiconductor exports value almost doubled from a year earlier, following an already strong 85% increase in the previous month. Auto exports remained resilient, rising 44% y/y, broadly in line with March. Exports of mechanical and electrical products grew 20% y/y, up from 11% in March, while home appliance exports returned to positive growth. In contrast, exports of furniture, general equipment and machinery continued to contract, albeit at a slower pace.

FIGURE 1. China April exports returned to double-digit growth...



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. ... with shipments to major partners improving

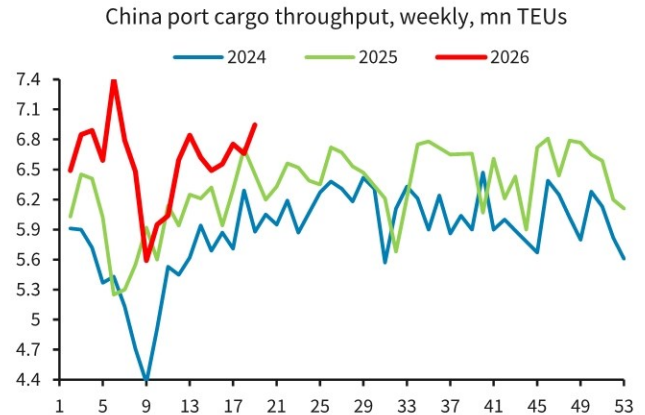


Source: Wind, Barclays Research

¹ "China clean tech exports jump as Iran war spurs demand", Bloomberg, 20 April 2026, "Oil Price Surge Fuels Chinese EV Sales Overseas", Yicai, 24 March 2026, "BYD Secures Another 2.6 GWh Overseas Order, to Supply 468 Energy Storage Systems for Four Solar Storage Power Plants in Chile", IT Home, 30 March 2026

FIGURE 3. Strong exports were led by AI-related and green-tech products

Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 4. High frequency shipping data showed still strong exports in May

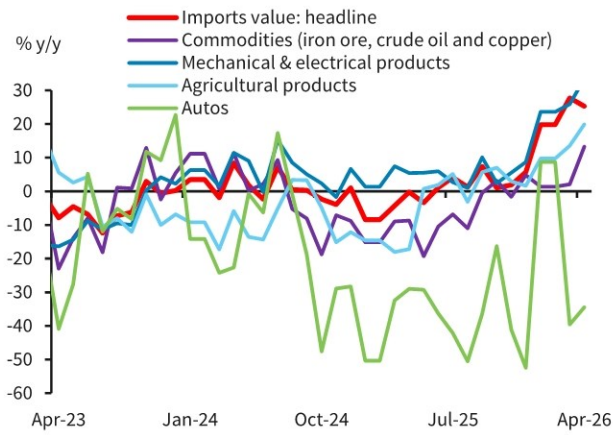
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

April headline imports posted a strong growth due to price effects

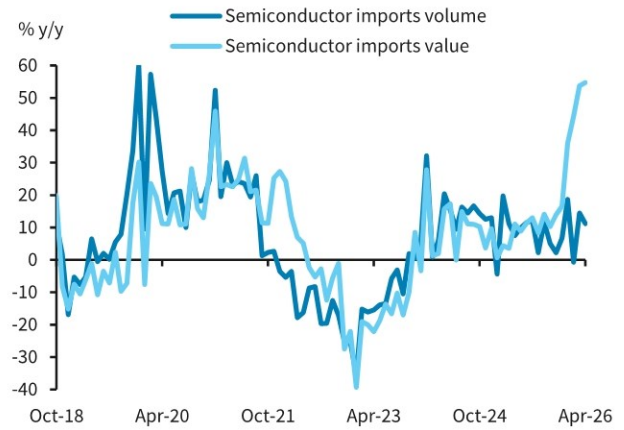
Imports have continued to exceed expectations this year. Against the backdrop of surging energy prices, and semiconductor related prices, China's import value growth posted a solid growth of 25.3% y/y in April, following a 27.8% increase in March, supported by robust imports of mechanical and electrical products (April: 33.5%, March: 26%), agricultural products (April: 20%, March: 13.6%), and commodities (April: 13%, March: 2%). In contrast, auto imports remained weak, falling 34% y/y after a 40% decline in March.

On a volume basis, imports of energy-related products weakened notably. Crude oil imports fell 20% y/y, widening sharply from a 2.8% decline in March. Natural gas imports dropped 13% (March: -11%), while coal imports fell 12.5%. Imports of industrial materials also stayed soft: iron ore import growth slowed to 0.7% from 11.5% in March, and steel imports declined 11% y/y, reversing a 2% increase previously.

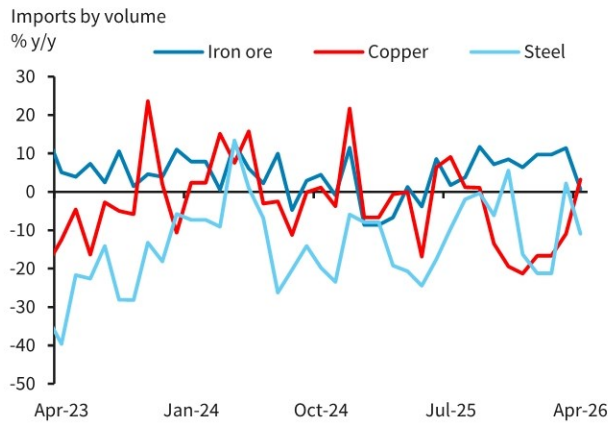
By contrast, soybean imports reached 8.48 million metric tons in April, more than doubling from 4.02 million tons in March. This marked a 39.4% y/y increase in April, following a 15% gain previously. Looking ahead, President Trump is scheduled to visit China for meetings with President Xi from 13–15 May, when China could likely pledge incremental purchases of US agricultural products (such as soybeans and corn), energy (including LNG and crude oil), and Boeing aircraft.

FIGURE 5. Imports by key categories

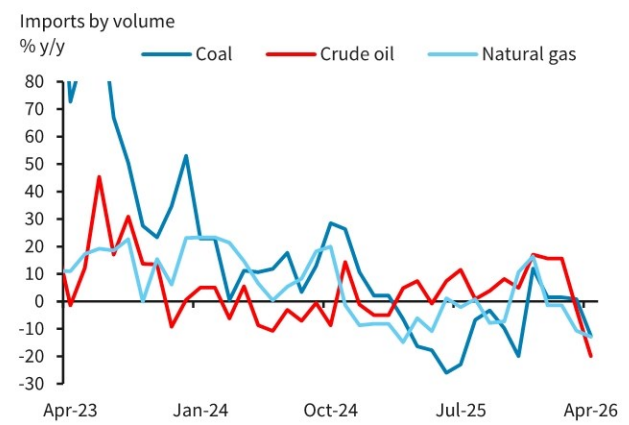
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 6. Semiconductor import value accelerated

Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 7. Imports of key industrial materials stayed soft...

Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 8. ... while imports of crude oil and natural gas weakened visibly

Source: Wind, Barclays Research

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